

Programmes of Study at Backwell School

We offer a wide range of courses at Level 3 (A Level or equivalent) including new courses such as the Applied Science and Health and Social Care AAQs (Alternative Academic Qualification) as well as courses that are new to our sixth Form this year, Politics and Criminology. The standard programme of study for Backwell Sixth Form students is three two-year courses plus, in Year 12 only, either the Extended Project Qualification, Core Maths, an additional AS Level or the Employability Award. Students achieving mostly grades 9 to 7 at GCSE may choose to study four A Levels over two years, and requests of this nature will be discussed at interview and post results day.

Two Year Courses

A Levels

A Levels are Level 3 courses for which exams take place at the end of Year 13 only. A small number of subjects also require the completion of coursework (NEA). Grades available vary from A* to E; this represents an equivalent range of ability to that covered by grades 9 to 4 at GCSE.

Cambridge Technical Diplomas (CTECs) and Advanced Academic Qualifications (AAQs)

These are Level 3 courses equivalent to A Level standard in which students focus on areas of the subjects in an applied way. Assessment is through six or more units over the two years, including exam units taken at different points across the two years. Successful students are awarded either Distinction Star (equivalent to A* at A Level), Distinction (A), Merit (C) or Pass (E).

One Year Courses

AS Levels and Core Maths

AS Levels and Core Maths are assessed by examinations in May of Year 12 and are graded from A to E (there is no A* grade at this level). AS Levels are equivalent to 40% of an A Level in terms of university tariff points, so alongside the intrinsic value of continued learning in a subject, they can boost applications to other courses. Please note that we only offer the following subjects at AS Level: Further Mathematics, Modern Languages and Music. Please see the course pages later in this booklet for more detail on the AS courses that we offer as well as Core Maths.

The Extended Project Qualification (EPQ), AQA

Students undertaking the EPQ will be expected to complete an independent research project which is either a 5,000-word extended report or a more creative or practical outcome with a report of 1,500 words. They deliver an assessed presentation on their work and complete and submit a project log, providing details of their research and how their project developed. At the end of the course, they will be awarded an AQA qualification worth 50% of an A Level. Students will learn through lectures, classes and individual meetings with their project supervisor. Because the project is submitted at the end of Year 12, students will be able to focus fully on their A Levels in Year 13.

EPQ students will develop skills, knowledge and understanding that they will be able to use when tackling similar projects in future study or employment contexts and it is an excellent way of setting candidates apart from their peers in the increasingly competitive world of Higher Education and employment. It allows students to demonstrate independence and extra commitment to their chosen area of study – especially at interview. Consequently, top universities value it greatly and some routinely give alternative offers to students who have studied the EPQ.

